

The Familiar Dark — Plot Document

Unified plot document for the Alderamontico jam game. Combines story canon and gameplay structure. Companion to the deeper backstory outline (the-familiar-dark-story-outline.md).

Project parameters

- 13-day jam, browser-based, AI game jam
 - Theme: “familiar”
 - “Not brem” alter ego project
 - Runs alongside Blue Fire as primary creative work
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Premise

A nighttime detective story. A blood-covered holy statue in a rural Alderamontico town turns anyone who touches it into Glass, and the Church has decided Acolyte Nessa is the witch responsible.

The player is a newly minted Intercessor, assigned alongside Brother Aldric to investigate. Through the investigation, the player comes to believe Nessa is innocent — though Aldric, who was once Nessa’s mentor, never wavers in believing she’s guilty.

At the end, Nessa is cast into the pagan lands. The player chooses whether to follow her or accept the system’s verdict.

The “**familiar**” **theme** is load-bearing: Aldric and Nessa are *familiars* — they were paired through the Church, with Aldric serving as her mentor.

The central question: *When the truth is not admissible, what do you do with it?*

The World

The **Grid** is the cosmological substrate Alderamontico’s living-era civilization is built on.

Church orthodoxy: *"The grid is a gift. It is not to be questioned, it is to be appreciated."*

The Witness of the Dark Lights is a holy statue. Site of Nessa's catastrophic rite.

Glass transformation: anyone who touches the bleeding statue turns to glass instantly.

Visceral consequence of the rite gone wrong. Glass-touched things linger — partial conversions, brittle remains, fused biological traces.

Grid sickness: people exposed to certain Grid forces don't get possessed — they get Grid-sick and go insane. They retain enough awareness to write down what they did.

Cyberghosts: consciousness can persist after Glass conversion. Trapped in objects, statues, biological traces.

The pagan lands: territory at the edge of Alderamontico. Where the church casts those it can't or won't redeem.

The Church: persecutes questioners. Treats curiosity about the Grid as transgression.

The Witching Hour rite: ritual intended to open portals to the Grid. Nessa's rite, intended for the Grid, opened to the pagan lands instead — through one of her friends, who somehow became the conduit.

The Cast

Acolyte Nessa

Always had a special interest in the Witness of the Dark Lights statue. She'd read next to it, about it, sit by it. She became an Acolyte specifically to deepen her knowledge of the Grid.

This made people suspicious already. Nessa didn't believe in the orthodoxy that the Grid couldn't be questioned. She wanted to know everything there is to know about it.

She self-assigned to the statue and began performing rites with friends during the Witching Hour. One night the statue began to bleed. Her friends touched it and turned to Glass instantly. Nessa screamed, alerting others, and was arrested as a witch before anyone understood what had truly happened.

Nessa is **imprisoned throughout the game**. The player only meets her in confinement.

Brother Aldric

Mentor figure to Nessa through the Church. Her *familiar*, paired by the institution.

Aldric believes Nessa is guilty no matter what evidence the player surfaces. His pain

isn't doubt about the verdict — it's love bounded by orthodoxy. He feels brotherly guilt about her fate, wishes it were different, but won't bend the truth as he sees it.

A tragic figure: the mentor whose love for the institution outweighs his love for the student. At the ending, Aldric stays behind. Familiarity wasn't enough; only the outsider can act.

The Player

Newly minted Intercessor, introduced at the opening ceremony cutscene. An outside agent — capable of coming to conclusions independent of church orthodoxy in ways Aldric cannot.

No prior relationship with Nessa. Conviction about her innocence develops through evidence over the course of the investigation.

Mara Vey

Nessa's closest friend. The unintended conduit. Her family carried pagan trace work — river offerings, basement candles, the folk practice the Church tolerates until it doesn't. Mara died as the doorway. Her hair, fused to her Glass remains, becomes the player's path to the truth.

Tollen Rusk and Iria Fen

The two other friends at the rite. Turned to Glass when they touched the bleeding statue.

The Widow

The fracture-touched widow. Lives along the river. Has personal experience with Glass-handling, the unresolved dead, and the witness-rite. Source of the witness-rite knowledge.

The True Story

(What the player is gradually uncovering. The answer key.)

Nessa found a forbidden document describing a *rite of near witness* — a way to contact the Grid through prepared sacred matter, without entering the Spire. She believed the Witness of the Dark Lights statue was the perfect vessel.

Her closest friend, Mara Vey, had been performing basement pagan rites with Tollen Rusk and Iria Fen. They were frightened rural young people trying to find spiritual language outside Church control. Nessa thought she was correcting their superstition with real knowledge. Mara thought Nessa was *giving their rites power*. Neither understood that

combining pagan under-rites with the Grid-contact rite would make Mara — not the statue — the living conduit.

At Witching Hour, the basement rite opened first. Nessa's Grid-contact rite latched onto it. Mara became the doorway. The statue answered. It began to bleed because sacred matter under Grid pressure started processing nearby life.

Tollen and Iria touched the bleeding statue and turned to Glass instantly. Mara died as the conduit. Nessa survived because she was reading the rite text, not touching the statue.

The Church saw forbidden rite, dead friends, lone survivor, history of obsession. Witch.

Love opened the door, not malice. That's the tragedy.

Class System

The player chooses a class at character creation. No matter the class, they become an Intercessor — class affects HOW they intercede.

Class slots (specifics TBD):

- **Scholar** — ranged sacred matter, documents/lore advantage
 - **Warrior** — melee with church arms, confrontation advantage
 - **Third class TBD** (Mystic? Sensitive to spirit traces, cyberghost interaction)
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Town Hub

The rural Alderamontico town. Lighter gameplay weight than the zones — investigation HQ, not a dungeon.

- **Aldric's office** — briefings, story-beat conversations, where new zones unlock
- **The prison** — visit Nessa periodically; dialogue evolves with what you've found
- **The Bleeding Witness cordon** — visible setpiece, the statue's hot zone. Off-limits beyond the church guard line but visible from town. Atmospheric anchor.
- **Shop / supply** — items, gear, save point
- **Inn / rest** — heal, advance time if needed

The town's mood shifts as the investigation progresses — NPC dialogue changes,

atmosphere darkens toward the verdict.

The Investigation — Three Zones

1. The Subterranean Pagan Network

Vibe. Mara Vey's basement was not unique. The town has an underground network of small ritual spaces beneath various houses, linked by tunnels older than the Church's arrival. Damp stone, candles, soil marks, family-shrine fragments.

Story role. First major zone. The player learns the pagan rites were real, organized, generational — not Mara's isolated experiment. Finds the basement where Mara's specific rite happened. Recovers fragments of the rite text and evidence of who else was involved.

Gameplay feel. Properly dungeony. Multi-floor, twisty, vertical where possible. Doors locked by sigils, hidden passages behind shrines.

Combat. Pagan rite remnants (semi-formed conduits left by interrupted rites), partial Glass conversions, the residual pressure of unfinished rituals.

Reward. Rite text fragments, names of Tollen and Iria's pagan-side connections, first clear evidence Mara was a willing participant — not Nessa's victim.

2. The Drowning Pool

Vibe. A flooded river basin outside town. Pagan river offerings have been made here for generations — old votives in the reeds, prayers tied to branches, soil marks at the bank. The boy from Nessa's youth drowned here. A sunken shrine sits beneath the surface, partially intact. Mist, reeds, drowning ambient noise.

Story role. The widow lives along the river — her house is flood-damaged, half-claimed by the water. Fracture-touched, knows witness-work, source of the witness-rite knowledge. Within the zone, the **playable Nessa flashback** triggers at a specific point — the place where the drowning happened. You play through her version of the memory and learn how Aldric reads her vs. how she actually is.

Gameplay feel. Water-based dungeon. Partial submersion, swimming sections, reed corridors, the sunken shrine as the dungeon's depths.

Combat. Drowned dead (echoes of those lost in the river), pagan river spirits (manifestations of generations of offerings), Glass-touched aquatic life. The drowned boy's echo as a haunting encounter near the flashback trigger.

Reward. The witness-rite from the widow. The playable Nessa flashback as emotional key.

Strong tonal payoff — water, memory, the dead who don't entirely leave.

3. The Pagan Lands

Vibe. Beyond the church's territory. Hostile, atmospheric, unfamiliar. What waits past Alderamontico's edge.

Story role. Only unlocked in the "run after" ending. Player pursues Nessa into exile. Aldric stays behind. The zone is the epilogue — what life looks like after rejecting the system.

Gameplay feel. Open exploration, fewer landmarks, more wilderness. Lighter than the other zones — endgame, not another full arc.

Combat. Pagan exiles (hostile to Intercessors), things from the lands proper, possibly a final encounter.

Reward. Find Nessa. Closing scene.

Story Arc

Act 1 — The Pagan Network. Opening Intercessor ceremony. Meet Aldric. First visit to Nessa in prison. Aldric assigns the investigation. Player learns the rites were generational.

Act 2 — The Drowning Pool. Travel to the river. Encounter the widow. Learn the witness-rite. **River flashback (playable Nessa)** triggers in the depths — you play through her version of the drowning. Returning to town, visit Nessa again — she begins to trust the player. Aldric grows uneasy.

Act 3 — Town climax. Gather Mara's hair from the Glass-fused remains at the statue cordon. Perform the witness-rite in town with Aldric present. Mara wakes. Truth surfaces. Aldric refuses.

Verdict. Church condemns Nessa. She is cast into the pagan lands. Final choice presented.

- **Epilogue (Run After) — The Pagan Lands.** Pursue. Find her. Closing scene.
 - **Epilogue (Let Her Go) — Town.** Stay. Closing scene with Aldric.
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Special Sequences

- **Opening Intercessor ceremony** — class selection wrapped into ceremony framing.
- **River flashback (playable Nessa)** — embedded in the Drowning Pool zone, triggered at

the site of the drowning. Underwater shrine, the drowning, the truth more complicated than Aldric remembers.

- **Witness-rite climax** — scripted sequence in town at the end of Act 3. Mara wakes. *"I opened."*
 - **Two ending sequences** — Stay / Run After.
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Endings — two options, no middle

Let Her Go — accept the system. Nessa is cast into the pagan lands. The player stays in the rural town / the church's domain. Player and Aldric end on the same side.

Run After — reject the system. Player pursues Nessa into the pagan lands. Aldric stays behind, still believing his student was guilty.

(No third option. A "complete Nessa's rite" alternative was considered and rejected as overshadowing the central plot.)

Tonal Anchors

"A land beyond hatred."

"A land measured in love."

"A land devoured by black light."

"Shall time bear its eternal witness."

"Alderamontico."

What's Still Open

- Class roster specifics (third class, exact skill distinctions)
- Town NPC roster beyond Aldric, Nessa, the Widow
- Music selections from the fusion library
- Whether the Bleeding Witness cordon is enterable at any point or stays cordoned throughout

- Asset pipeline (tilesets per zone, enemy variants)